

Pool Draw (Same-Country Split) & Advancement Rules

Reference note for Technical Supervisors — compiled from the FIVB Beach Volleyball Sport Operations Manual (edition Feb 2026) and the VW Beach Pro Tour Futures in Europe 2026 Event Rider.

1. Splitting Same-Country Teams into Pools (Main Draw)

The Futures Main Draw is 16 teams split into 4 pools of 4 (Pool A–D), using the Modified Pool Play format. Seeds 1–4 are placed directly as pool anchors (Seed 1→A, Seed 2→B, Seed 3→C, Seed 4→D); the remaining seeds are then assigned pool-by-pool via a serpentine draw (Draw 1 and Draw 2), by seeding groups.

1.1 Host country teams — mandatory separation

The top 4 seeded host-country teams must never be placed in the same pool. This is enforced, not by re-drawing, but by shifting the seed of the conflicting team:

- The best host-country team is seeded #1 in Pool A if it ranks among the top 4 seeds overall; otherwise it is placed as Seed #4 in Pool D.
- For the 2nd, 3rd and 4th host-country teams: if the natural draw would place one of them in a pool that already contains a top-4 host team, its seed is increased first (e.g. Seed #5 → #6) to find a free pool.
- If increasing the seed does not work (or is not possible), the seed is reduced instead (e.g. Seed #16 → #15) until the team lands in a different pool.
- The relative seeding order of the top 4 host-country teams must still be respected when they are shifted.
- A 5th, 6th, or further host-country team is NOT subject to this restriction — it may fall in the same pool as one of the top 4 host teams.

Worked example (FIVB Sport Operations Manual, §15): host country has 6 teams in the Main Draw — USA1 (Seed #1), USA2 (#2), USA3 (#5), USA4 (#8), USA5 (#10), USA6 (#15). The natural draw would place USA1, USA4 and Qualifier-3(USA) in Pool A/B together with USA2/USA3/USA5 clustered — so USA3 and USA4 are seed-shifted (USA3 #5→#6, USA4 #8→#9) until the top 4 host teams (USA1, USA2, USA3, USA4) each land in a separate pool. USA5 and USA6/Qualifier(USA), being outside the top-4 host group, are left where they fall, even if that means sharing a pool with a top-4 host team.

1.2 Foreign (non-host) teams from the same National Federation

The FIVB Sport Operations Manual does not set an explicit “max per pool” cap on foreign teams from the same NF at Futures level (unlike, e.g., the Senior World Championships, where a hard cap of 2 teams from the same NF per pool applies). In practice this is bounded indirectly, because the Country Quota (Section 2) already limits a foreign NF to a maximum of 2 teams directly in the Main Draw — so at most 2 same-NF teams can ever be in the pool draw pot to begin with.

Do not confuse this with the Senior World Championships rule (48-team pools of 4): there, teams from the host country can never share a pool, and foreign NFs are capped at 2 teams per pool, with a fresh draw if a 3rd same-country team lands in an already-full pool. That stricter rule is NOT written into the Futures chapter.

1.3 Knock-out stage carry-over

After the pool phase, the top 3 teams per pool (12 teams) advance to the single-elimination bracket. Teams that were in the same pool cannot meet again in the first two knockout rounds (Round of 12 and Quarterfinals) — this protects against a repeat pool clash, not a nationality clash. Teams from the same NF that were drawn into different pools ARE allowed to meet in these first two knockout rounds; there is no NF-based protection at this stage.

2. Country Quota (context for both draws)

Futures is one of only two Beach Pro Tour levels with a country quota (the other being The Finals). Elite and Challenge currently carry no country quota.

Entry type	Host NF	Foreign NF
Direct to Main Draw (excl. wild cards)	Max 3 teams	Max 2 teams per NF
May instead enter Qualification	4th team, if enough ranking points	Remaining teams, if enough ranking points
Total per NF (excl. wild cards)	4 (within quota)	4 (within quota)
Extra reserve allowance	2 extra “host reserve” teams, outside the quota, to cover late withdrawals into Qualification	None — excess teams go to the bottom of the general reserve list

Any team over the quota is placed at the bottom of the reserve list. If a National Federation has more eligible teams than its quota allows, the NF itself runs an internal “Country Quota Playoff” (off-site, before the event) to decide which of its teams take the available spots — no such matches are played on-site at the Futures event.

3. Qualification → Main Draw: Restrictions

3.1 Standard path

The Qualification Tournament is a straight 16-team single-elimination bracket (no pools, no explicit same-country separation rule in the draw). The 4 teams that win through the bracket advance automatically to the 16-team Main Draw, filling the 4 remaining Main Draw slots alongside the direct entries and the Main Draw wild cards.

3.2 Exceptional path — late withdrawal from Main Draw (“lucky loser”)

If a directly-entered Main Draw team withdraws after the Preliminary Inquiry of the Qualification Tournament (i.e., once the Qualification schedule is already published), the vacancy is NOT simply given to the next-ranked Qualification loser automatically — it is resolved by a Lucky Loser draw, with these restrictions:

- Conducted by the FIVB Technical Delegate, after the Main Draw Preliminary Inquiry.
- Only open to teams that lost in the LAST round of the Qualification Tournament (i.e. the semi-finals of the qualifying bracket).
- A team is only eligible if it attends and signs in at the Main Draw Preliminary Inquiry as a ‘lucky loser’ (strongly recommended, though attendance at the draw itself is not mandatory once signed in).
- Draw procedure: the two highest-seeded eligible lucky losers are drawn against each other first; for each further open spot, the next highest-seeded remaining team is drawn against the loser of the previous match, continuing until all vacancies are filled.
- If several direct-entry teams withdraw in this window, the highest-ranked team already advanced from Qualification fills the highest vacated seed position, then the 2nd-highest, etc. — lucky losers are always slotted into the bottom seed positions (Seed #16, then #15, etc.).

3.3 Replacement of an athlete/team already in the Qualification or Main Draw

A change-of-athlete or replacement request is governed by ranking points, not automatic promotion:

- A replacement for a Main Draw team keeps that Main Draw slot only if it has enough entry points to justify the position; otherwise it drops to the Qualification Tournament — and if it lacks enough points even for that, it drops further to the reserve list.

- A replacement for a Qualification team keeps that slot only if it has enough entry points to hold it, and is reseeded per the new team's points; if it also has enough points to enter the Main Draw outright, it still stays in Qualification at its original position (only reseeded), it does not jump to the Main Draw through this mechanism.

4. Reserve List → Qualification: Restrictions

When a Qualification Tournament vacancy opens (withdrawal, insufficient points on a change-of-athlete, etc.), promotion from the reserve list follows a strict order and eligibility checks:

- 1st priority: the next eligible team within the general country-quota reserve list, in ranking-points order.
- 2nd priority: the 2 designated “host reserve” teams (the extra host-NF teams held outside the quota), taken in order of ranking points; ties between host reserve teams are broken by a written confirmation of priority from the host NF (submitted by the -28 days’ deadline), or by drawing of lots if still tied.
- 3rd priority: any remaining teams outside the country quota altogether, picked up strictly by entry-points order, only once the two priority pools above are exhausted.
- A reserve team must be **PHYSICALLY PRESENT** at the Preliminary Inquiry of the Qualification Tournament to be picked up; if no eligible general-reserve team is present, the call goes straight to the host reserve list.
- The National Federation quota cap (max 4 teams excl. wild cards, per Section 2) must be respected at every step of the reserve promotion — a reserve pick-up can never push an NF over its quota.

Sources

FIVB Beach Volleyball Sport Operations Manual, edition 16 February 2026 — §2.5 (Country Quota), §4.1.2 (Withdrawals: Challenge/Futures), §15 (Volleyball World Beach Pro Tour – Futures).

VW Beach Pro Tour Futures in Europe 2026 — Event Rider (CEV/FIVB, issued 17.11.2025), Country Quota Playoff note.